

Oklahoma - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | SEC

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ◆ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	A legitimate top-15 team with an elite defensive identity and unusually valuable QB/OC continuity.
Preseason consensus	AP No. 10, 1,047 points · SP+ No. 11
Returning production	68% (No. 7) overall · Off. 75% (No. 4) · Def. 61% (No. 34)
Primer power rating	+19.0 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	7.5 wins · most likely 8-4
Net vs. 2025	● ↔ Similar top-15 underlying quality with a higher offensive ceiling from continuity, offset by a defense replacing a large professional class and one of the nation's hardest schedules.
Confidence	Medium-high

2026 identity: Oklahoma pairs QB John Mateer/OC Ben Arbuckle continuity with WR Isaiah Sategna III and WR Trell Harris outside; the run game and protection remain the offensive questions.

Bottom line: Oklahoma has top-15 quarterback, defense and special-teams quality, but SOS No. 4 magnifies the unsettled OL/RB picture and a major defensive reload.

Beats expectations if: QB Mateer/OC Arbuckle lift offensive efficiency, C Jake Maikkula and OT Michael Fasusi stabilize the line, and the returning defensive core preserves elite play-level results.

Disappoints if: The RB hierarchy stays unsettled, C Jake Maikkula's absence revives protection problems, and defensive attrition shows late against the schedule's difficult finish.

Five things to remember

- 1 National baseline:** Oklahoma is No. 11 in SP+ (+18.8), No. 10 in the AP poll and No. 7 in the SEC preseason media poll; consensus is firmly top-15, not conference-favorite.
- 2 Coaching:** Returning production is 68% overall (No. 7) and 75% on offense (No. 4), with John Mateer returning as the clear QB1 under the same offensive play-caller, Ben Arbuckle.
- 3 2025 baseline:** The 2025 defense was elite: No. 3 EPA/play allowed, No. 2 success rate allowed, No. 3 havoc created, No. 9 explosive-play prevention and No. 3 rush defense.
- 4 2025 baseline:** The offense's 2025 weakness was structural, not cosmetic: No. 113 rush offense, No. 93 success rate, No. 85 explosiveness and No. 103 havoc allowed.
- 5 ? Key uncertainty:** Danny Saili's Oklahoma membership/eligibility remains unresolved; he is not assigned a 2026 role.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	10-3 (6-3 SEC)	● Excellent
Scoring	26.2 PPG	● Average / mixed
Total offense	354.3 YPG	● Below average
Rush offense	118.5 YPG · 3.5 YPC	● Poor
Pass efficiency	7.11 YPA · 17 TD / 11 INT	● Average / mixed
Third downs	38.6%	● Average / mixed
Scoring defense	15.5 PPG allowed	● Elite
Total defense	272.5 YPG allowed	● Elite
Rush defense	77.3 YPG · 2.4 YPC	● Elite
Pass defense	195.2 YPG · 6.24 YPA · 11 TD allowed	● Very good

Oklahoma’s 10 wins were defense-led. The 2026 upside comes from QB John Mateer/OC Ben Arbuckle lifting an offense with clear efficiency and protection headroom.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+3.62 · No. 37	● Good / above average
Off. EPA/play	+0.054 · No. 47	● Good / above average
Off. success rate	41.2% · No. 93	● Below average
Off. explosive-play rate	11.6% · No. 85	● Average / mixed
Havoc allowed	16.7% · No. 103	● Below average
Opp.-adjusted defense	+11.01 · No. 6	● Elite
Def. EPA/play allowed	-0.269 · No. 3	● Elite
Def. success rate allowed	30.2% · No. 2	● Elite
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	8.1% · No. 9	● Elite
Havoc created	22.5% · No. 3	● Elite

Advanced-stat read: The defense was elite across every major play-level measure. The offense was respectable by adjusted/EPA ratings but poor at staying on schedule and avoiding havoc.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC / defensive play-caller	Brent Venables - returning	● ↑ Stable defensive identity is especially valuable through heavy attrition
OC / play-caller	Ben Arbuckle - returning	● ↑ Mateer/Arbuckle continuity is the clearest offensive improvement lever
Co-DC / run defense / DT	Todd Bates - returning	● ↑ Front continuity supports an elite run-defense identity

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ RB Lloyd Avant	Colorado State	● ↔ Lead-back candidate in an open competition.
◆ WR Trell Harris	Virginia	● ↑ Major-role addition with Biletnikoff recognition.
◆ WR Parker Livingstone	Texas	● ↔ Adds major-rotation competition.
◆ TE Hayden Hansen	Florida	● ↔ Leading major-role candidate in a rebuilt TE room.

Out	To	Loss
OL Febechi Nwaiwu	NFL (Houston), Round 4, No. 106	● ↓ Major loss from an already unsettled line.
WR Deion Burks	NFL (Indianapolis), Round 7, No. 254	● ↓ Material receiving production leaves.
RB Jaydn Ott	NFL (Kansas City Chiefs), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Significant loss from an open RB hierarchy.
WR Keontez Lewis	NFL (Tampa Bay Buccaneers), undrafted free agent	● ↔ Meaningful receiving loss.
RB Taylor Tatum	Michigan	● ↔ Adds to backfield turnover.

Offensive net: ● ↔ QB/OC and top-receiver continuity lift the ceiling, but the RB hierarchy and OL are less settled than the 75% returning-production headline suggests.

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ LB Cole Sullivan	Michigan	● ↔ Rotation/starting competition for a strong LB room.
◆ DB Dakota Fields	Oregon	● ↔ Adds depth after veteran secondary losses.
◆ DL Bishop Thomas	Georgia State	● ↔ Provides front depth during a major reload.
◆ DL Kenny Ozowalu	UTSA	● ↔ Brings another front-rotation option.

Out	To	Loss
DL R Mason Thomas	NFL (Kansas City), Round 2, No. 40	● ↓ High-end loss from an elite front.
DL Gracen Halton	NFL (San Francisco), Round 4, No. 107	● ↓ Second major DL loss.
DL Damonic Williams	NFL (Arizona Cardinals), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Deepens the interior turnover.
EDGE Marvin Jones Jr.	NFL (Seattle Seahawks), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Material edge loss from the No. 3 havoc defense.
DB Kendal Daniels	NFL (Atlanta), Round 4, No. 134	● ↓ Starting-caliber secondary loss.

Defensive net: ● ↓ The 61% returning-production signal and Stone/Lewis/Bowen core keep the unit strong.

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Ben Arbuckle/John Mateer continuity with a more complete run-pass goal	QB John Mateer plus WR Isaiah Sategna III/WR Trell Harris	Run-game, protection and early-down efficiency must improve
Defense	Brent Venables' aggressive, disruptive run-first defense	DL David Stone, LB Kip Lewis and the Bowen brothers preserve a high-end spine	Heavy professional attrition tests depth and finishing power
Special teams	Experienced, recognition-heavy specialist group	K Tate Sandell, P Grayson Miller and LS Ben Anderson	Few obvious weaknesses; must sustain the model-level baseline

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● B+	● ↔	High	QB John Mateer returns with OC Ben Arbuckle and clear QB1 status.
RB	● C+	● ↓	Medium-low	RB Lloyd Avant leads an unsettled room after major turnover.
WR	● B+	● ↔	Medium-high	WR Isaiah Sategna III returns; WR Trell Harris and WR Parker Livingstone add depth.
TE	● B-	● ↔	Medium	TE Hayden Hansen leads a capable but unsettled rotation.
OL	● C+	● ↔	Medium-low	OT Michael Fasusi anchors a line still awaiting C Jake Maikkula and better protection.
DL/Edge	● B+	● ↓	Medium-high	DL David Stone leads a talented front replacing several NFL departures.
LB	● A-	● ↔	High	Kip Lewis and Owen Heinecke form a highly recognized returning core.
Secondary	● A-	● ↓	High	Peyton and Eli Bowen anchor a strong back end.
Special teams	● A	● ↔	High	K Tate Sandell, P Grayson Miller and LS Ben Anderson form an elite specialist group.
Coaching	● A-	● ↔	High	Brent Venables and Ben Arbuckle preserve play-calling continuity on both sides.
Overall	● A-	● ↔	Medium-high	Top-15 QB/defense/specialist profile with an 8-win median, held below elite by OL/RB uncertainty and SOS No.4.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 22, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
John Mateer	QB	● High-end returning QB1	Maxwell · Walter Camp POY	The QB/OC continuity is Oklahoma's best route from a defense-led 10-win team to a more balanced contender.
David Stone	DL	● Nationally elite defensive cornerstone	AP 1st team · Walter Camp 2nd team · SEC 2nd team · Bednarik · Outland	The professional exodus up front makes his ability to anchor the new front indispensable.
Isaiah Sategna III	WR	● Core returning playmaker	SEC 2nd team · Biletnikoff · Paul Hornung	Most proven returning perimeter piece in an offense that needs better down-to-down efficiency.
Kip Lewis	LB	● High-end returning linebacker	SEC 2nd team · Bednarik · Nagurski · Butkus	Central piece in preserving the elite success-rate/havoc identity.
Peyton Bowen	DB	● Top returning secondary anchor	SEC 2nd team · Bednarik	Pairs with Eli Bowen to stabilize a secondary replacing multiple NFL/portal departures.
Michael Fasusi	OT	● Projected left-tackle anchor	SEC 2nd team	His health and form are critical to fixing a 2025 offense that allowed havoc at a No.103 rate.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Jake Maikkula	C	● Returning center / key availability monitor	Rimington	The line is much easier to trust if he returns quickly; no firm timetable is established.
Tate Sandell	K	● Nationally elite specialist	AP 1st team · Walter Camp 1st team · SEC 1st team · Lou Groza	Special teams can steal field-position/score value in a schedule full of near-toss games.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	One of the nation's hardest: Oklahoma plays at Michigan and Georgia before the Red River game, then closes with four straight top-20 SP+ opponents.
Difficulty	● 10/10 · Brutal · SP+ SOS No. 4
Hardest stretch	at Florida -> Ole Miss -> Texas A&M -> at Missouri
Swing games	at Michigan, Texas (neutral), at Florida, Ole Miss, Texas A&M, at Missouri
Advantage	UTEP and New Mexico at home provide two early reset games, and Kentucky/South Carolina/Ole Miss/Texas A&M are home SEC games.
Expected	7.5 wins · most likely 8-4
Floor / ceiling	6-6 / 10-2

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	A No.10 AP/No.11 SP+ team will not be hidden, but the defense and specialist quality can make Oklahoma more attractive as an underdog or short favorite than as a large favorite.
Back them when	Receiving points or laying a small number in games where Venables' front can dictate rushing downs and Mateer is protected well enough to avoid negative plays.
Fade/pass when	Asked to lay a premium before Maikkula/first-five OL and RB hierarchy are stable, especially against defenses capable of recreating the No.103 havoc-allowed problem.
Key monitor	Jake Maikkula return timeline, Final offensive-line five, RB hierarchy / Tory Blaylock clearance, Trell Harris full participation, Danny Sails membership/eligibility
Week 1 baseline	Oklahoma -40.5 vs. UTEP · rating-only fair baseline; compare with the live market before betting. Live market: Oklahoma -41.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Oklahoma's ceiling hinges on the offense becoming less dependent on an elite defense. QB John Mateer and OC Ben Arbuckle provide rare continuity, while WR Isaiah Sategna III and WR Trell Harris give the passing game enough playmaking to improve if the line and run game cooperate.

Brent Venables still has a high-end defensive spine despite major NFL losses, and special teams is a strength. SOS No. 4 keeps the margin thin, making **7.5 wins and 8-4** a sensible baseline for a top-15-caliber team with real upside and real attrition risk.

About this primer

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [coaching](#) · [fall camp](#) · [NFL departures](#) · [position/camp update](#) · [Venables Names Arbuckle Offensive Coordinator](#) · [Venables Agrees to 2-Year Contract](#) · [Brent Venables staff biography](#)

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